Den of Lions (2)

By Terry Anderson

INTRODUCTION

The job of a war correspondent is well established. They show us countries in chaos, burning, disintegrating, engulfed in something so terrible we can only pity them and give thanks that what we are witnessing is taking place on the other side of the world. They open our eyes to a contemporary history we can no longer ignore. However, this work can often come at a terrible personal cost. Terry Anderson in his memoir Den of Lions described his life as a war correspondent both before and after his capture in Beirut, Lebanon in 1985. Den of Lions by Terry Anderson.

HIGH WIRE (page 29)

The high-wire artist risks his life
to please the crowd, for fame,
the thrill of danger, and the pleasure
of performing feats that few can do.

[HOWEVER] . . . you cannot go on bathing
in the world's violence unscathed,
touch so many people's pain and grief
and not be burned. Tell me you could

4NG Fanatics

look into a hundred children's eyes,
dark, huge with uncomprehending
pain and hunger, and purge yourself
of all you feel in a thousand words or so.
So we grow our shells. Those who can't
don't last. Some grow them all too well --
the cynical, abrasive ones who
cannon feel. Perhaps they never could.

Most of us just try to keep our balance,
like the man up on the wire,
eyes fixed straight ahead,
Never daring to look down.

INTRODUCTION

Because if you dare to look down in a country torn apart by war . . . this is what you see

The child is dying of his wounds
and others' hatred.
His body, stretched by growth
and pain and malnutrition,
lies bare before us,
tubes like hungry snakes
invading every orifice.
There's no affront in this indignity;

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

our shames lies in the pits
left in his flesh by burning phosphorus.
This is the vile, unpardonable
result of all our follies;
the last, unnamed, and mortal sin
that even God cannot forgive.
We'll write of this in bitter,
Burning words, and be convinced
they'll have effect because
the paper's dotted with our tears.
We must believe; it's why we do this.
The only point can be if we prevent
or somehow ease the next child's dying.
there will be one – there always is.
We'll watch it, and we'll write again in rage,
and cry our helpless tears. (page 38)

TRANSITION

Terry Anderson saw children, both victims and predators, during his assignment to Lebanon. He once said, "To teach a child to hate is probably the biggest sin anyone can commit, because you not only destroy that child's life but you destroy so many other lives, as that child grows and spreads hatred."

4NG Fanatics

THE CHILDREN (page 130-131)

These are your children,
fierce in hatred, bathed in blood;
the ones you handed guns at ten or twelve
and set against their brothers.
So many died; they can be mourned,
Turned into martyrs and exalted.
What will you do with those who live?
The war is over now, you say,
it's time for reconciliation.
They don't know that word,
never having heard you use it.
They're more familiar with
words like "Kill. Destroy."
Put down your guns. Forgive
your brother. Go to work,
you order. Work at what?
They have no skills, except for war.
Many cannot even read.
The minds of others have been twisted,
scorched by sights and acts
too terrible to tell.
The young are resilient.
Most will probably obey
again, and gladly turn their energies to peace.
Those that don't you'll punish

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

like so many untrained,
disobedient dogs, until
they come to heel.
Some you'll have to kill --
the taste for blood
will never leave them.
But about forgiving,
it's not their brothers
they'll have trouble with,
It's you.

TRANSITION

On March 16, 1985, Terry Anderson was abducted by a radical Muslim group called Hezbollah, the "Party of God." What is it like to exist for seven years in darkness and chains, not knowing from one day to the next how much longer you will be a prisoner? Anderson discovered how the human spirit can reach beyond the bars of prison. It is a matter of "Faith"

Where is faith found?
Not in a book,
or in a church,
not often or
for everyone.
In childish times
it's easier;

4NG Fanatics

a child believes just what it's told.
But children grow
and soon begin
to see too much
that doesn't match
the simple tales,
And not enough
of what's behind
their parents' words.
There is no God,
the cynics say;
we made Him up
out of our need
and fear of death.

What of those
who in their need
and pain cry out
to God and go
on suffering?
I do not know –
I wish I did.
Sometimes I feel
all the world's pain.
I only say
that once in my
own need I felt

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

a light and warm
and loving touch
that eased my soul
and banished doubt
and let me go
on to the end.
It is not proof --
there can be none.
Faith's what you find
when you're alone
and find you're not. (pg 98 – 99)

PATIENCE (pg 167)

Patience is not a virtue --
it's a necessity, a survival trait,
an ever-filling well from which
I sip, or gulp, exhausted
by the desert of this nonlife.
My faith surges and recedes;
hope sometimes abandons me,
leaving only patience.
I kick and scream and flail
inside my head; patience
offers only soft resistance,
washing gently at my rage.
I know if I dive deeply,

4NG Fanatics

I will find patience, hope, and faith
emerging from a single source,
eternal and unchanging.

TRANSITION

Struggling to find faith, hope and patience during the many isolated hours of his captivity was one challenge for Terry Anderson. Attempting to understand and forgive his captors was another. But how can one understand or even begin to define evil in a dark, war-torn world?

Satan is a name we use
for darkness in the world,
a goat on which we load
our most horrific sins,
to carry off our guilt.
But all the evil I have seen
was done by human beings.
It isn't a dark angel
who rigs a car into a bomb,
or steals money meant for others' food.
And it wasn't any alien spirit
that chained me to this wall.
One of those who kidnapped me
said once: "No man believes he's evil."
A penetrating and subtle thought
in these circumstances, and from him.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

And that's the mystery:
He's not stupid, and doesn't seem insane.
He knows I've done no harm to him or his.
He's looked into my face
each day for years, and
heard me crying in the night.
Still he daily checks my chain,
makes sure my blindfold is secure,
then kneels outside my cell
and prays to Allah, merciful, compassionate.
I know too well the darker urges in myself,
the violence and selfishness.
I've seen little in him I can't recognize.
I also know my mind would shatter,
my soul would die if I did the things he does.
I'm tempted to believe there really is
a devil in him, some malefic,
independent force that makes him
less or other than a man.
That's too easy and too dangerous an answer;
It's how so many evils come to be.
I must reject, abhor and fight against
these acts, and acknowledge that
they're not inhuman - just the opposite.
We can't separate the things
we do from what we are;
Hate the sin and love the sinner is not

4NG Fanatics

a concept I'll ever really understand.
I'll never love him - I'm not Christ.
But I'll try to achieve forgiveness
because I know that in the end,
as always, Christ was right.

STIGMATA VI (pg 118)

[But . . . .] Evil dealt with daily
becomes familiar, even ordinary.
Communication can begin,
and some small understanding,
but soon runs into walls of
background, belief, and circumstance.
The logic is too different;
mental language untranslatable.
There's no shared view of God or man.
Oppressor and oppressed,
Each sees the other
a victim bound and blind.

TIONAL USE

4NG Fanatics

CONCLUSION

The Lebanese Civil War drew to a close in the early 1990s . . . however, conflict in the Middle East still rages on with millions of Syrian refugees, both women and children, seeking asylum. History is, indeed, again repeating itself. Syrian war correspondents face more than the threat of capture and being held hostage. Today, live streaming video on the internet provides images to incite the world. On August 19, 2014; just over 600 days after his capture by ISIS, American photojournalist James Foley was beheaded as a message to America to stay out of the conflict. And America was outraged . . . and rightly so . . . but where is the outrage for the Syrian children who continue to die, and for the Syrian refugees who continue to be turned away.

In the words of Terry Anderson, nearly 40 years ago, "Satan is a name we use for darkness in the world," . . . I fear the darkness has only just begun.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Terry Anderson
ISBN: 978-0345467928
Publisher: Ballantine Books
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1995

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY